Mental Health First Aid Handbook

A Practical Guide for Supporting Children & Teenagers



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Chapter 1: Understanding Mental Health

What Is Mental Health?

Mental health is the way your mind feels, thinks, and handles life.
It includes your emotions, your thoughts, how you cope with stress, how you relate to people, and how you make decisions.





Just like your body can feel strong or tired, your mind can also feel happy, worried, overwhelmed, confused, calm, or sad, and all these feelings are part of mental health.

Having good mental health doesn't mean you are happy all the time.
It means you can:

- *Understand your feelings,*
- *Cope with challenges,*
- *Ask for help when things get tough,*
- *Keep friendships and relationships,*
- *Take care of yourself.*



The feeling thermometer

Think of your emotions like a thermometer that rises and falls:



Boiling Zone

You feel overwhelmed, scared, or out of control, this is when you need help immediately.

Hot Zone

Your stress is getting strong and hard to manage.

Warm Zone

You feel a bit stressed or worried, but still okay.

Cool Zone

You feel calm, happy, and in control.

Chapter 4: Mental Health First Aid Steps

LOOK

Notice early signs that you or a friend may be struggling.



Examples of what to look for:

- Sudden sadness, anger, or anxiety
- Avoiding friends or activities
- Changes in eating or sleeping
- Falling grades or difficulty concentrating

LISTEN

Offer calm, non-judgmental listening.

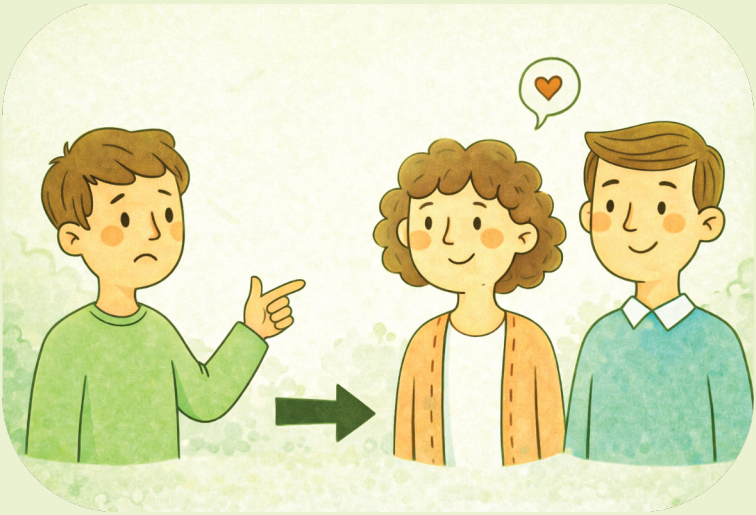


How to do it:

- Sit with them in a quiet place
- Say things like “I’m here for you” or “You’re not alone”
- Let them talk without interrupting or giving lectures

LINK

Help them connect to safe support.



Who to link to:

- A trusted teacher
- School counsellor
- Parent or guardian
- A nurse or community health worker